

The Science of Leadership: A Theoretical Model and Research Agenda

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Abstract

I review the empirical literature on leadership, focusing on papers published since 2010. To do so, I introduce a framework composed of two features: whether theories (*a*) involve the study of leaders or leading (i.e., the person versus the process) and (*b*) conceptualize leadership as a cause or a consequence (i.e., an independent versus dependent variable). This framework can enable future research to accumulate in a more programmatic fashion and help scholars determine where their own studies are located within the landscape of leadership research. I end the review by critically evaluating existing work, arguing that the most popular subcategory of leadership research—lumped conceptualizations of leading, in which scholars examine multiple leader behaviors within a single construct—has significant limitations and may need to be replaced by a greater focus on split conceptualizations of leading, wherein scholars isolate single leader behaviors.

1. INTRODUCTION

All disciplines have quintessential topics that reside at the center of scholarly attention. At the core of physics is the study of quantum mechanics, at the heart of modern medicine is the germ theory of disease, and at the center of economics sits the Keynesian paradigm. Organizational psychology is no different. In addition to topics such as motivation and teamwork, one subject that has captivated scholars since the field's inception is leadership (Yukl et al. 2002). A comparison of the definitions of "organization" and "leadership" reveals the overlap between these two ideas: An organization is a collective in pursuit of a common purpose, and leadership is a process in which a person or set of people influence others to pursue a common purpose (Ouchi 1980). The parallels are self-evident and profound. Consequently, leadership remains one of the most well-studied topics in organizational psychology (Day 2000, Yukl et al. 2002).

In this article I review the empirical literature on leadership using a framework composed of two features: whether theories (*a*) involve the study of leaders or leading and (*b*) conceptualize leadership as a cause or a consequence (i.e., an independent versus dependent variable). I organize the literature within and between each of these categories, and then end the review by critically evaluating existing work, making several recommendations. Given the sheer scale of accumulated evidence, I focus primarily on research published in top management and psychology journals since 2010. For reviews that provide a relatively comprehensive synthesis of leadership theories in earlier periods, see Glynn & Raffaelli (2010) and Yukl et al. (2002). For prior reviews of topics relevant to leadership in this outlet, see Day & Dragoni (2015), Den Hartog (2015), Kozlowski et al. (2016), Liden et al. (2016), Antonakis et al. (2016), Tepper et al. (2017), Lyness & Grotto (2018), and Lord et al. (2020).

2. ORGANIZING THE LEADERSHIP LITERATURE

The teleological distinction between leaders and leading is rooted in how both concepts are defined. A leader is typically conceived as an individual who has a unique degree of status or authority with which to alter the behavior of others toward mutually agreed upon objectives (Pfeffer 1977). As I explain below, this status can be formal or informal, but most perspectives assume that both the leader and his/her/their follower(s) believe(s) that the leader has some legitimate claim to authority. As noted above, the act of leading is typically defined as a social influence process in which an individual or individuals attempt to influence others toward a common purpose (Yukl et al. 2002, Locke 1999).

Both theoretically and statistically, a key distinction between leaders and leading is the level of analysis. In multilevel theory, the individual resides at a higher level of analysis than any behavior that this individual may enact (Kozlowski & Klein 2000). Any individual leader may exhibit dozens or hundreds of distinct leader-relevant behaviors across the course of a single day, such as communicating vision, clarifying deliverables, and making resource allocation decisions. Although most individuals tend to act in consistent ways across time, each day they will enact some behaviors but not others, and the manner and order in which they exhibit them may vary considerably. Indeed, behavior may vary just as much—and possibly more—within leaders versus between leaders (Judge et al. 2002, Kenny & Zaccaro 1983, McClean et al. 2019; see also Hall et al. 2009 and Kenny & Livi 2009). Although their behavior varies each day, however, their personal attributes, including their demography and the degree to which their role as a leader is formally designated, remain relatively constant over long periods of time.¹ Similarly, other peoples' attributions of

¹ Some person-level attributes can certainly vary. For instance, leader identity can oscillate from situation to situation (Day & Sin 2011). Accordingly, temporal stability is a general mark of leader-level attributes rather than an invariant, definitional feature.

them—such as how capable they are to take on the role of a leader—tend to remain relatively stable (Epitropaki & Martin 2004, Dinh & Lord 2012; see also Hall et al. 2009 and Kenny & Livi 2009).²

The distinction between leader behaviors and leaders themselves is reflected by two traditions in the literature. The study of leaders is largely drawn from the social cognitive, identity, diversity, and personality traditions. It relates to questions such as which people emerge as leaders, how they are categorized, and how they are evaluated—each of which depends on viewing leaders as individuals who have stable attributes (Lord et al. 1984, Meindl 1995, van Knippenberg & Hogg 2003). By contrast, the study of leading (i.e., the process of leadership) primarily draws from the tradition that focuses on antecedents and consequences of discrete behaviors, such as giving feedback to employees. In this tradition, researchers focus on how behaviors influence a target's psychological states (both cognitive and affective) and, in turn, the target's behavior. For instance, the act of a leader admitting mistakes describes a bounded behavior that can be repeatedly observed in situ, even if it might be manifest in slightly different ways each time.

In short, a trait or psychological construct used to categorize a person's inherent characteristics (e.g., a leader's age) is more stable and thus fundamentally distinct from an externally observable behavior aimed at influencing others (e.g., a leader blaming a follower for a mistake) (Gravetter & Forzano 2011, p. 75). The study of leaders involves who leaders are and the positions they attain, whereas the study of leading involves how leaders exact influence as well as the processes they enact. Given these related distinctions, I employ the study of leaders and the study of leading as the primary organizing principles of this article (see **Figure 1**). Toward the end of the article, I address the question of how leaders and leading can be studied together, given that they are inextricably intertwined, as it is leaders who do the leading. I also discuss when they can be understood separately, given that some individuals may be formally designated as leaders but fail to lead, whereas others who do not possess the label of leader can alter the behavior of others in ways that reflect the act of leading. In addition to the leaders/leading distinction, I employ a secondary organizing principle: leadership can be understood as a cause or a consequence. That is, both leaders and leading can be investigated as either an independent or a dependent variable (Glynn & Raffaelli 2010) (see **Figure 1**).

3. THE STUDY OF LEADERS

Scholars often examine leadership not as a process that is agnostic to the person who is doing the leading but with an eye toward understanding the leader as an individual.

²In reality, there are more than just two levels of analysis. For example, a leader's one-time outburst may be nested within that person's broader tendency to have frequent outbursts. And this tendency might be nested in a general disposition to engage in abusive leader behaviors. In turn, this disposition may be nested within even broader personality characteristics (e.g., narcissism), which in turn may be nested within demographic characteristics that are completely, or almost completely, immutable (perhaps people born during one generation tend to be more narcissistic than others). Higher levels of analysis are more stable and enduring, and lower levels more granular and fluid. Critically, whether behavior is examined as a one-time episode or a more general tendency, it will be nested within numerous person-level attributes that do not change or change very infrequently. In this way, the hierarchical nesting of behavior within stable person-level factors remains relevant even if behaviors themselves can be conceptualized at different levels of granularity. For the remainder of the article, I thus treat behavior associated with leading as the lower level of analysis and person-level factors associated with leaders, such as traits, orientations, and social standing, as the higher level of analysis. Yet it is important to underline the reality that these hierarchical differences are not necessarily dichotomous or invariant.

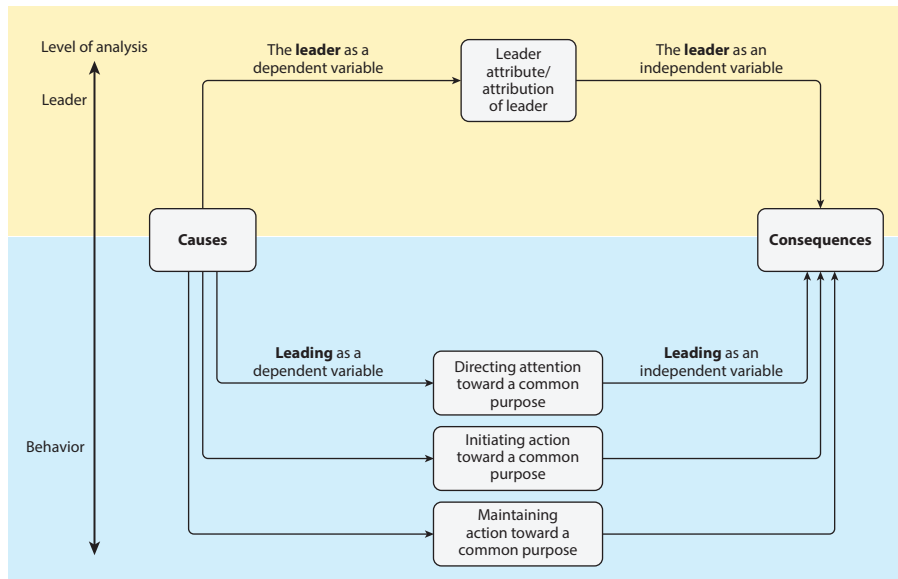


Figure 1

Two core attributes of leadership research: leaders versus leading and causes versus consequences. Extant research can be organized into four basic categories: leader behaviors (i.e., leading) as predictors or as outcomes and leader-level concepts (e.g., leader personality and perceptions of leaders) as predictors or as outcomes.

3.1. The Leader as an Independent Variable

Inspired by research in personality psychology, industrial/organizational psychology, human resources, and human factors, leadership scholars have long been interested in leader traits, dispositions, and other individual differences (Judge et al. 2002). These variables reflect the leader's general orientation across time and situations (DeRue et al. 2011). In this vein, scholars who examine the leader as an independent variable typically seek to understand how the leader's stable personality characteristics (leader traits) affect a range of outcomes, such as performance. This can include general habits and styles of behavior—but rather than considering behavior as episodic, contextualized, and “of the moment,” a leader-level perspective focuses on behavioral tendencies—that is, how leaders tend to act across time and situations.

One of the most dominant trends of the past decade involves the dark side of leader personality. This research has unearthed a series of negative consequences of one dark trait in particular: narcissism. Narcissistic leaders engage in less task, relational, and change-oriented behaviors, are less responsive to indications that their risks are backfiring, and are more likely to be bolstered by social praise (Chatterjee & Hambrick 2011, Martin et al. 2016). Moreover, Gupta & Misangyi (2018) found that narcissism imbues leaders with an inflated sense of their own discretion, and Zhu & Chen (2015) found that narcissistic leaders often deliberately go against their directors' suggestions in order to establish their superiority. What prompts narcissistic leaders to engage in the most extreme forms of destructive behavior? Possibly a mix of thin skin and vindictiveness: Liu et al. (2017) revealed that narcissistic leaders are especially prone to engage in self-interested behavior when they feel slighted by their organizations. Ultimately, however, the relationship between narcissism and leadership might be weaker than often presumed: a meta-analysis of 92 samples found that psychopathic traits in leaders, including narcissism, are only weakly associated

with leader effectiveness, although the detrimental effect of these attributes is stronger for male leaders (Landay et al. 2019).

In addition to increasing their attention on narcissism, scholars have continued to focus on the Big Five personality factors: conscientiousness, agreeableness, neuroticism, openness, and extroversion. The general pattern that unifies these findings is the following: Longstanding beliefs about the advantages of some attributes, such as extroversion and conscientiousness, have come under scrutiny. Consider extroversion. Some findings reinforce received wisdom that extroverted leaders have an advantage. For example, Gupta & Misangyi (2018) found that extroverted CEOs are better at issue-selling because they are more assertive and more interested in building the social and political capital needed to facilitate change. However, Grant et al. (2011) drew on dominance complementarity theory to assert that extroverted leaders only yield strong performance when their followers are deferent. By contrast, proactive followers prefer more introverted leaders. In a similar vein, research over the past decade suggests that leader conscientiousness has surprisingly mixed effects (Badura et al. 2020, DeRue et al. 2012, Marinova et al. 2013). This may be because leaders who are conscientious have a tendency to get bogged down in detail and struggle to give followers a bigger picture view of how their work fits into the organization's overall mission. In a similar way to how scholars have discovered that the advantages of extroversion and conscientiousness are bounded, there also may be a curvilinear effect for another trait that many would assume to be strictly positive: intelligence. Leaders who are too smart might have "too much of a good thing," perhaps because they are more likely to engage in overanalysis at the expense of decisiveness (Antonakis et al. 2017).

In short, research on the traits that have received the most attention from leadership scholars over the past decade—especially narcissism, extroversion, conscientiousness, and intelligence—suggests that the relationships between leader traits and key outcomes have important boundary conditions and are not as straightforward as previous evidence and conventional wisdom might suggest.

3.2. The Leader as a Dependent Variable: The Role of Categorization, Identity, Networks, and Leader Well-Being

Scholars who investigate the leader as a dependent variable are interested in what happens to leaders themselves. This involves questions such as how leaders emerge and how the responsibilities of being a leader impact their well-being. It typically involves one of the following four approaches: implicit leadership theories, identity-based theories, network-based theories, and perspectives on leader well-being.

3.2.1. Implicit leadership theories. Rooted in research on social cognition, theories involving attribution, categorization, and evaluation relate to how leaders are perceived as well as outcomes that hinge on these perceptions, such as leader selection and emergence (Foti et al. 2017, Shondrick & Lord 2010). The seminal work in this space has examined how people often jump to conclusions about a person's leadership effectiveness based on little or no information about their behavior. Drawing from attribution theory, Meindl (1995) established that people often infer leader effectiveness not by observing a leader's behavior but rather the outcomes that they presumed were caused by the leader: When organizations and groups perform well, leaders are presumed to be effective. A largely separate line of work is rooted in categorization theory. Lord et al. (1984) introduced leadership categorization theory (LCT) according to the premise that people have cognitive schemas about effective leaders based on leaders they have encountered elsewhere, such as personal experience and history textbooks.

Whereas attribution-based theories have largely sputtered in the past 15 years, LCT has flourished. One of the main reasons is that LCT can account for an especially pernicious facet of cognition: instantaneous categorization. Even though leading is defined as a social influence process, and evaluators certainly do infer leadership potential from actual leader-relevant behavior [such as task-oriented communication patterns (Gerpott et al. 2019)], people jump to conclusions about a person's leadership capability based on seemingly irrelevant information. This is because people engage in a largely subconscious process in which they evaluate leaders according to how well they match prevailing leader prototypes. This may include information such as how much a person talks (MacLaren et al. 2020), but, more disconcertingly, people often judge a person's leadership potential without any information at all about that person's behavior. This includes a target's physical attributes or social category membership. This has made LCT an important vehicle for understanding why minority leaders experience discrimination. For example, the prototypical leader is assumed to be White (Rosette et al. 2008). As a result, the success of minority leaders is often attributed to the situation or to attributes that are irrelevant to leadership, whereas failure is attributed to their personhood (Carton & Rosette 2011, Park & Westphal 2013).

Peoples' perception of a prototypical leader may shift depending upon the situation. For instance, evaluators prefer minorities more when their skillset matches the context, such as the presumed fit of Asian Americans to engineering versus sales (Sy et al. 2010). Similarly, people may prefer Asian American leaders when organizations are failing, because they are presumed to be more communal in their orientation (Gündemir et al. 2019). Finally, the link between stereotyping and leader outcomes can sometimes be circuitous. Zapata et al. (2016) found that minority leaders are more likely to experience stereotyping and undermining from their own subordinates when they treat their subordinates kindly. When subordinates are treated well, they do not pay close attention to their supervisors because they do not feel a sense of threat from them. However, this can create self-perpetuating spirals of discrimination because subordinates are more likely to stereotype leaders they do not pay attention to.

In addition to race, much of the work on implicit theories over the past decade has been devoted to gender. Some of this research points to a disadvantage for women leaders. For example, McClean et al. (2018) found that men who speak up promotively were assumed to be promising leaders according to a rank ordering mechanism, whereas women who spoke up promotively were not. Similar to research showing that racial minorities are viewed as prototypical leaders only during exceptional periods, research on the glass cliff effect suggests that women may be preferred when firms are failing because they are assumed to be communal and self-sacrificing, and that this typecasting effect might reinforce the belief that women are not fit to lead when organizations are meeting or exceeding expectations (Ryan et al. 2011; see also Koenig et al. 2011).

Other trends have established that women leaders have a more general advantage. In a meta-analysis of 99 studies, Paustian-Underdahl et al. (2014) found that evaluators perceive women as more effective leaders than men. This may cause women to sometimes get more credit than men for enacting similar leader behaviors (Lanaj & Hollenbeck 2015). However, there are important boundary conditions on the advantage that women leaders have (Lanaj & Hollenbeck 2015). For instance, Rosette & Tost (2010) found that the preference for women leaders was limited to top-level positions (see also Leslie et al. 2017). Paustian-Underdahl et al.'s (2014) above-mentioned meta-analysis indicates that the most reliable advantage men have is in their own self-regard, as they tend to rate their own leadership more generously than women rate themselves.

Finally, some research has identified points of tension between different implicit leadership theories. One example is the connection found between LCT (Lord et al. 1984) and romance of leadership theory (Meindl 1995) in the effort to explain bias against Black leaders (Carton & Rosette 2011).

3.2.2. Identity-based theories. A related line of research involves identity-based theories of leadership. The logic is similar to that of categorization theory: Leaders are more likely to emerge when their attributes align with follower expectations. However, the basis for that alignment is not necessarily whether a person looks a certain way but whether their values and preferences align with those of followers (Hogg et al. 2012, Stam et al. 2014). The specific nature of identity will vary depending on what followers value. This can include relational identity (Chang & Johnson 2010), cultural identity (Lord & Brown 2001), and organizational identity (Sluss et al. 2012). For example, Lam et al. (2018) found that proactive employees identify more strongly with proactive leaders, especially when those leaders are more proactive than their predecessors, thereby creating a contrast effect that amplifies the congruence between leader and follower identities. These identities are also central to the mutual sensemaking process between followers and leaders insofar as both parties engage in an iterative process in which some people claim the identity of a leader while others decide whether to bestow that identity onto them, thereby accepting the identity of a follower (DeRue & Ashford 2010).

Along these lines, in addition to the role of follower identity in predicting leader emergence, the leader's own personal identity plays a key role. Simply put, leaders are unlikely to invest the time and energy required to claim the identity of being a leader and all that this entails (vying for leadership positions, undergoing leadership training, and accepting the risks of being a leader) unless they define themselves, at least in part, as a leader (DeRue & Ashford 2010, Kwok et al. 2018, Petriglieri & Stein 2012). In this vein, Guillén et al. (2015) found that people ascertain whether they are a leader by comparing their self-concept to well-known examples of leaders and their general understanding of what a leader is and should be.³

3.2.3. Network-based theories. Although theories centered on categorization and identity remain the dominant paradigms for understanding leader evaluation, some research influenced by sociology takes a broader view by examining how the leader's social network shapes when and why they emerge as leaders. For instance, Chiu et al. (2017) found that managers in more centralized networks are more likely to be endorsed by others as leaders. This echoes earlier findings showing the power of network centrality for driving perceptions of leader charisma (Balkundi et al. 2011). As another example, Brands et al. (2015) found that male leaders are seen as more charismatic when they occupy central roles in their social networks, whereas female leaders are seen as more charismatic when their networks are cohesive. Other work has expanded the investigation beyond relational ties to include network structures based on perceptions. For instance, DeRue et al. (2015) found that network patterns of peoples' perceptions of warmth and competence drove whether leaders emerged and whether their power was centralized or distributed.

3.2.4. Leader well-being. The body of leadership literature that is perhaps most exclusive to the past decade is that on leader well-being. Tracking the increased academic interest in mental health, scholars have begun to challenge the implicit assumption that only positive outcomes ensue when people occupy leadership positions. Although it is true that leader positions come with esteem, influence, and access to scarce resources, scholars have begun to uncover numerous downsides. In an experience sampling study, Foulk et al. (2018) found that leaders who experienced more psychological power perceived more incivility from others, harming their well-being. In a

³Although the extent to which people see themselves as a leader tends to be stable across long periods of time, it can (and often does) change within-person insofar as people who previously did not see themselves as leaders sometimes do at a later point, and vice versa (Miscenko et al. 2017).

similar vein, Gabriel et al. (2020) found that becoming a leader made people more isolated. Recent research suggests that some employees are aware of many of these risks and thus avoid becoming leaders in the first place (Zhang et al. 2020). On the flip side, Li et al. (2020) found that becoming a leader can increase one's conscientiousness but does not affect emotional stability, suggesting that the effects of assuming leadership roles are mixed and demand more attention.

4. THE STUDY OF LEADING

A behavior is an observable action that takes place in situ (e.g., providing task instructions). Authors sometimes take for granted that they are studying leading so long as the behavior under investigation is being enacted by a person who is formally designated as a leader. Although this approach is certainly an intuitive one, it culminates in two untenable conclusions. First, because almost any behavior can be enacted by most leaders, a working definition of leading as behaviors enacted by leaders is too inclusive to be helpful for organizing the literature. If leading can be everything, then it cannot be anything. Indeed, many behaviors exhibited by people in positions of formal authority will not necessarily reflect leading (Kniffin et al. 2020). Second, it would result in the circular logic that only people who are formally recognized as leaders can exhibit behaviors consistent with leadership, which is unfounded given that, at least from a logical standpoint, a person does not need to meet any formal preconditions in order to motivate other people toward a common purpose. To be sure, followers may need to perceive a person as having some legitimate status in order to permit that person to have influence over them (DeRue & Ashford 2010)—but it need not be formally designated (Lord et al. 2016). An alternative way to organize the literature is according to whether a behavior has a notable impact on an outcome that seems relevant to leading, such as follower performance. But behaviors centrally associated with leading cannot be identified or understood from a conceptual standpoint merely by examining their consequences; anointing a behavior as central to leadership merely because it reliably predicts key performance outcomes is inherently atheoretical and tautological.

To avoid these problems associated with circularity, a systematic indexing of the literature requires an identification of the behaviors most central to the root conceptualization of leading. Most definitions of leading converge on the following core tenets: Leading is an influence process that involves attempting to motivate followers toward a common purpose (see Vroom & Jago 2007 for an overview of relevant definitions). Given that motivation is the root action-oriented term in common conceptualizations of leadership, it would be informative to turn to theory on motivation to distill the principal attributes of leadership. Motivation involves three issues: directing, initiating, and maintaining effort (Latham & Pinder 2005). A person must first decide what they want to achieve, and then take action and persist as they attempt to achieve it. Given that a common purpose is a part of most definitions of leading, it follows that leading involves *directing people toward a common purpose and then influencing them to initiate and maintain effort in their pursuit of it*. The term purpose can be understood as reflecting a specific target or general end-state. As such, this definition is consistent with the active pursuit of a specific target (e.g., becoming the most profitable company in the industry) (Locke 1999) as well as the pursuit of more diffuse end-states that reinforce the organization's underlying value system (e.g., an individualistic culture) (Yukl 2008). In this way, any given study can be classified as an examination of leading rather than merely a study of actions performed by a leader to the extent that it meets these criteria. I use this conceptualization to organize the literature on leading, again focusing primarily on the past decade of empirical research.

4.1. Leading as an Independent Variable

Behavior can be perceived and understood at various levels of abstraction (Lieberman & Trope 1998), ranging from a single behavioral episode that is defined richly and can be observed in situ (a person speaking about their company's vision to a colleague on a Thursday afternoon) to the tendency for many different types of behaviors that are unlikely to be enacted at the same time to covary and thus potentially be united by some common theme (e.g., admitting mistakes and asking followers for feedback can perhaps be united by the theme "humility"). Additionally, a single behavior or a cluster of covarying behaviors can be enacted more or less consistently across time and different situations (e.g., a person's tendency to communicate about long-term visions rather than short-term goals on various days and in different situations)—a point to which I return, below, when discussing the fluid boundaries between discrete leader behaviors and longstanding dispositions, styles, orientations, characteristics, and traits.

Given that scholars can study either single behaviors that tend to unfold in a single sequence of actions versus clusters of different behaviors that unfold in different settings, scholars have taken two basic approaches to understanding how the act of leading causes key organizational outcomes. The first involves investigating single, observable behaviors within single domains, such as communicating vision or providing feedback. The second involves behavioral composites in which scholars aggregate multiple leadership behaviors into a single construct, such as assessing whether a leader articulates a clear purpose, makes ethical resource allocation decisions, and provides followers with autonomy. In principle, scholars can aggregate any number of discrete behaviors—from two to an indefinite number—into a single construct. Yet, as I review below, scholars who deploy this composite approach typically incorporate at least seven, and often many more, behaviors into meta-constructs. In practice, this has resulted in bipolarization, such that scholars tend to fall into one of two extremes: either investigating one behavior at a time or lumping several (or sometimes several dozen) behaviors into a single meta-construct. This bifurcation reflects the longstanding distinction between such "splitters" and "lumpers" (Cronbach & Gleser 1957, Judge et al. 2002), wherein the splitter contingent investigates behaviors that can be observed as single episodes in situ, such as a leader who admits a mistake, whereas the lumpers contingent synthesizes separate behaviors that covary yet do not unfold at the same time and in the same situation.

4.1.1. Splitters: research that isolates leadership behaviors. To examine the first dimension of leading—directing followers toward a common purpose—scholars continue to pay careful attention to the language of leadership (Steffens & Haslam 2013). The type of language most central to the establishment of a common purpose is that which refers to overarching goals, including vision, mission, aspirations, ultimate goals, and superordinate goals. Carton et al. (2014) argued that leaders establish a common purpose in part by communicating visions with more concrete, image-laden rhetoric (e.g., "our vision is to make moviegoers laugh") rather than abstract rhetoric (e.g., "our vision is to make people happy"). This not only gives each employee a clear mental picture of what the organization strives to accomplish but also gives different employees the same mental representation. Leaders can also make abstract values appear more proximal if they have an image-laden goal that can be used as a real-life symbol of the organization's broadest aspirations. An example is when John F. Kennedy motivated NASA employees by remarking that "knowledge and peace are [on the moon]," thereby making the organization's ultimate goals appear more closely connected to day-to-day work (Carton 2018, p. 336).

In addition to communicating with imagery, leaders may be able to further reinforce a shared sense of purpose by communicating a limited number of values (e.g., "our vision to make moviegoers laugh brings to life our core value of maximizing customer satisfaction") rather than a long

list of values that leads different employees to focus on different principles (Carton et al. 2014). This positions different employees to understand the broader meaning of the vision in the same way. A shared vision has many important consequences. For instance, Griffin et al. (2010) found that leader visions can spur both adaptive and proactive behaviors. It may also spur coordination and creativity (Carton et al. 2014). At the individual level, a common purpose spawned by a vivid vision increases employee persistence (Carton & Lucas 2018).

Although language is the most direct and pragmatic way to establish a common purpose, leaders can reinforce a shared sense of purpose through other means. For instance, organizations can make use of ritualistic behavior in which employees attend events together and engage in ceremonial routines, creating emotions that reinforce the sense that they share the same values (Lepisto 2021). Another way to ensure that employees feel a common sense of direction during vision pursuit is by allowing and even encouraging their involvement in key decisions—that is, licensing participation. In a sample of 65 firms, Ashford et al. (2018) found that CEOs who pair vision articulation with feedback seeking improve firm performance. However, of the two variables, feedback seeking was more instrumental for improving the extent to which top management teams worked effectively together.

The second dimension of leading—helping followers initiate action toward a common purpose—has been understudied over the past decade; however, some important advancements have complicated received wisdom. For example, although it is well-known that one of the most effective ways to impel followers into action is through subgoals and related targets, such as deadlines, it is important that these targets not be viewed as so challenging that employees do not initiate action in the first place. To the extent that employees are not intimidated by stretch goals, they can spur innovation because they require employees to think outside the box and develop new capabilities (Gary et al. 2017, Lemoine et al. 2016).

Once leaders achieve the first two motivational steps—articulating a compelling vision and jumpstarting employees into action—they must focus on motivating employees to persist. In the past decade, scholars have moved beyond extrinsic incentives and rewards to a more cognitive understanding of persistence, emphasizing the role of suborganizational visions and subgoals, perhaps because these cognitive markers are more likely than extrinsic rewards to lead to internalized and identified motivation, wherein employees see a personal connection to the organization's vision (Ryan & Deci 2000). One tactic is a suborganizational vision—a vision that a unit head crafts to lead the people they directly supervise. Suborganizational visions are an important instrument for allowing employees—especially those who work for peripheral units in an organization—to identify with an aspiration that is tailored to their own identity and interests while also linked to the organization's broader vision (Lewis & Clark 2020). In a similar vein, leaders can encourage followers to partake in the process of vision crafting. In a study of 197 leader-follower dyads, Kearney et al. (2019) found that communicating a common vision ensures that leaders control their organization's direction as long as the leader simultaneously empowers followers such that they have the opportunity to shape and own the vision.

In addition to suborganizational visions, leaders can make use of subgoals, which provide a short-term referent that employees aspire to achieve and a clear demarcation between success and failure. In addition to helping employees regulate effort, subgoals can help employees see a connection between their day-to-day work and the organization's vision. For example, John F. Kennedy helped employees see a connection between their day-to-day work and the objective of landing on the moon by articulating three subgoals: reaching Earth's orbit, breaking Earth's orbit, and reaching the moon's orbit (Carton 2018). Subgoals can vary in terms of how they are supervised and how they are set. In terms of how they are supervised, leaders who are deeply involved in the day-in, day-out process of managing subgoals are more effective at promoting

persistence than those who involve themselves only as goal deadlines draw near (Chen & Nadkarni 2017). Regarding how they are set, there are still more questions than answers, suggesting an area that is ripe for future research. For instance, little is known about the ideal number, time range, and level of subgoals, as well as how these characteristics vary by context. For example, whereas a greater number of subgoals may help employees regulate their effort and stay on course, too many subgoals may cause employees to become so distracted by details that they lose sight of how their work connects to a shared vision (Carton 2018). Beyond subgoals, there are a number of other tactics through which leaders can motivate persistence, including their affective tone (Staw et al. 2019) and their efforts to shed light on the social impact of their employees' day-to-day work (Grant 2012). However the role of leading in driving follower persistence remains a relatively neglected area of research and is in need of fresh insights.

4.1.2. Lumpers: research that synthesizes multiple leader behaviors into single constructs.

Numerous theories agglomerate many distinct behaviors, usually ranging from a dozen to several dozen, into a single construct. Typically, these theories are labeled “[*adjective*] leadership” insofar as they reflect a bundle of behaviors that pertain to a common theme. This includes authentic leadership (Gardner et al. 2011), empowering leadership (Cheong et al. 2019), ethical leadership (Bedi et al. 2016), humble leadership (Feng et al. 2014), servant leadership (Van Dierendonck 2011), and transformational leadership (Wang et al. 2011). In some cases, scholars will emphasize one or a subset of these behaviors in their theorizing, yet still use the multi-behavior index in the methods. In these cases, the empirical test adds to the existing body of evidence for these lumped theories.

Most of these theories feature behaviors that fit into at least one of the three aforementioned tenets of leadership—directing action toward a common purpose, initiating action, and maintaining action—however, most of them include several behaviors that cut across these categories while also incorporating behaviors that are less essential to the definitional core of leading. For instance, transformational leadership features one behavior that is central to leading (vision communication) and others that are less central, such as tailoring messages toward each person as an individual. It is important to note that there are many different conceptualizations and measures within each leadership theory; therefore, in each case I introduce the construct with a conceptualization and measure that has been published in the past decade in a top outlet and epitomizes how scholars employ the construct.

A prototypical model of empowering leadership is composed of 24 distinct behaviors, including giving followers responsibility, encouraging initiative, showing concern, listening, and recognizing followers' strengths and weaknesses (Amundsen & Martinsen 2014). It has been linked to outcomes such as organizational citizenship behaviors (van Dijke et al. 2012), creativity (Zhang & Bartol 2010), team development (Lorinkova et al. 2013), goal setting (Schilpzand et al. 2018), and innovation (Chen et al. 2011).

A popular model of ethical leadership involves 38 behaviors, including holding followers accountable, giving subordinates influence, exhibiting concern for environmental sustainability, showing interest in followers, clarifying expectations, and keeping promises (Kalthoven et al. 2011). Schaubroeck et al. (2012) found that ethical leadership boosted unit ethical culture. Mayer et al. (2013) found that a leader's ethical behavior is most likely to drive ethical actions (e.g., whistleblowing) when it is not only the leader who is ethical but also peers. Importantly, ethical leadership may not always have expected effects. Leaders who act ethically one day may act more abusive the next day because they are depleted from regulating their own behavior (Lin et al. 2016).

A popular approach to understanding humble leadership involves nine behaviors, including actively seeking feedback, acknowledging when others have superior skills, complimenting others on their strengths, and being willing to learn from others. Humble leadership has been linked to an empowering organizational climate (Ou et al. 2014), performance (Owens et al. 2013), and team creativity (Hu et al. 2018). It may curb deviance but also promote it by enhancing employees' sense of entitlement (Qin et al. 2020).

A version of paradoxical leadership involves five dimensions, each of which is associated with multiple behaviors. This includes combining self-centeredness with other-centeredness, treating subordinates uniformly while allowing individualization, and maintaining decision control while allowing autonomy (Zhang et al. 2015). It increases collective self-efficacy (Shao et al. 2019), employees' ability to manage goals (Pearce et al. 2019), and proactivity (Zhang et al. 2015).

A prevalent model of servant leadership is composed of 28 behaviors, including recognizing when something is going wrong, emphasizing community service, and not compromising ethical principles (Liden et al. 2014). It has been linked to organizational identification (Liden et al. 2014), team effectiveness (Hu & Liden 2011), and performance (Chen et al. 2015, Liden et al. 2014).

A widely studied version of transformational leadership features more than 10 behaviors sorted into four classes, including inspiring followers through vision communication, considering them individually, and challenging them intellectually (Bass & Avolio 1994). It has been linked to performance (Grant 2012), regulatory focus (Johnson et al. 2017), and helping behavior (Wang & Howell 2010). It also enhances job performance (Zhang et al. 2014).

In sum, the literature has devoted substantial attention to leading as an independent variable, with the primary emphasis on lumped (rather than split) frameworks.

4.2. Leading as a Dependent Variable: Development and Interventions

Leading is often driven by “upstream” antecedents. In particular, industrial/organizational psychologists and human resource scholars continue to expand our repository of knowledge on leader training and development. This work is predicated on the idea that leaders are not merely born but can be made—an assumption that has long been questioned but was recently given strong support in Lacerenza et al.'s (2017) meta-analysis. The authors aggregated 335 samples and discovered powerful effects for leader development programs on a variety of behaviors, including how leaders react to threats. They also examined a variety of moderators. Some are intuitive. For instance, on-site training worked better than virtual training. Yet others were surprising. For instance, 360 degree feedback may not provide an advantage over feedback from a single source, and longer training programs are more effective than shorter ones (debunking long-held assumptions that longer programs are depleting and may promote reactance). Other findings were perhaps intuitive in terms of the direction of the effect but still surprising in terms of magnitude. To illustrate, high-level leaders are not merely less likely to acquire new leader behaviors than low-level leaders; they are four times less likely.

A related literature is that on leader interventions—frameworks or nudges that can cultivate desirable behaviors. One point of weakness among many leaders involves vision communication. Carton et al. (2014) found that approximately 90% of leaders communicate abstract visionary rhetoric (e.g., “make people happy”) even though concrete visions (“make moviegoers laugh”) are more likely to motivate and coordinate employees—findings consistent with prior research on leader communication (Emrich et al. 2001). To combat this so-called blurry vision bias, Carton & Lucas (2018) found that leaders craft more image-laden visions when instructed to mentally project themselves deep into the future and imagine witnessing a vivid, real-life moment that will take place once their organization's vision is achieved. For example, the leader of a computer repair company may envision her employees feeling proud when a customer calls to express gratitude

for their efforts. This approach works better than explicitly instructing leaders to use image-based words, suggesting that some leader interventions should be indirect.

5. INTEGRATING THE STUDY OF LEADERS AND LEADING

A small number of articles over the past decade have investigated the distinction between leaders and leading. One of the key insights from this research is that it is possible for individuals to enact behaviors central to leadership (e.g., vision communication) without being formally designated as leaders, and likewise people who are formally designated as leaders might not exhibit exclusively (or even primarily) behaviors that fall within the domain of leading (Ashford & Sitkin 2019, Bedeian & Hunt 2006). That is, leading does not require a formal leadership position, and a formal leadership position does not guarantee leading.

Another perspective relates not to drawing distinct boundaries between leaders and leading but to mapping the interplay between them. There are two basic ways this can be manifest: causal relationships and contingent relationships.

5.1. Causal Relationships

Consistent with the notion that leaders and leading can both be understood as independent or dependent variables, it is possible that one can cause the other. First, exhibiting actions associated with leadership, such as vision communication or providing feedback to others as they pursue long-term goals, can cause a person to attain a leadership position and/or affect them once they ascend to a leadership role. For example, Gerpott et al. (2019) found that individuals who communicated about change were more likely to emerge as leaders early in a team's project, whereas those who focused on relationships were more likely to emerge as leaders later in the team's project. This suggests that communication patterns determine which people emerge as leaders and when.

The second is when characteristics of the leader cause leading. The straightforward way this can be understood is with respect to traits, dispositions, and styles predicting leader behaviors, as these individual differences typically reflect general ways of behaving across time and situations. For instance, a person's trait extroversion might predict behaviors such as information sharing and feedback seeking such that extroverted people are more likely to share information and seek out feedback. However, there are less direct (and less intuitive) channels. For instance, a leader's religious identity can prompt a self-fulfilling prophecy, such that followers who have the same identity infuse the leader with more credibility, which then empowers the leader to exhibit more effective behaviors (Jackson & Johnson 2012). In a similar vein, Johnson et al. (2012) found that individualistic and collective identities combine to predict which leaders are likely to enact transformational behaviors. Accordingly, a leader's identity can be a distal cause of their own subsequent leadership behavior (Day & Sin 2011; see also DeRue & Ashford 2010). This is a process involving social perception insofar as targets see how other people treat them—such as deferring to them or deriding them—and they interpret this treatment in a way that increases (or decreases) their own self-identification as a leader, which, in turn, shapes how they behave. The first row of **Figure 2** provides a visual depiction of the two basic causal relationships between the study of leaders and leading.

5.2. Contingent Relationships

Most contingent approaches examine how the consequences of leading are moderated by attributes of (or attributions employees make of) the leader—a type of person-times-behavior

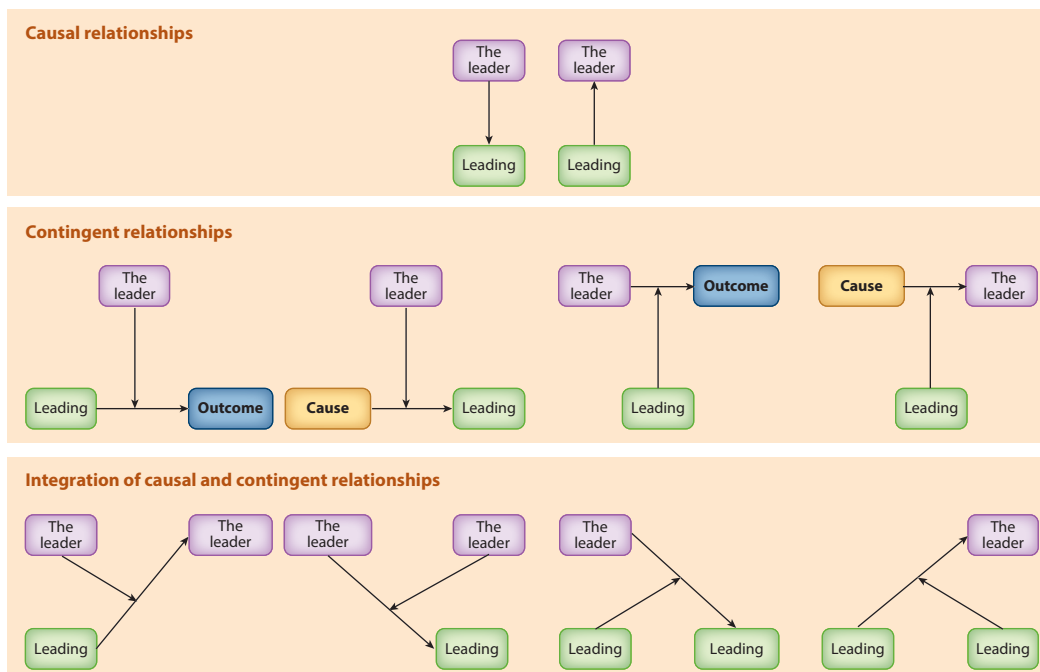


Figure 2

Integrating theory on leaders and leading: causal versus contingent approaches. The figure outlines a number of ways that leader behaviors and leader-level concepts can be connected. For example, the effectiveness of vision communication (a leader behavior) might depend on the characteristics of the leader who is doing the communicating (a leader-level perception).

interaction. For example, Eisenberger et al. (2010) found that the association between leader-member exchange and affective organizational commitment was greater when employees believed their supervisor's personal qualities reflected the central identity of the organization (e.g., a highly compassionate supervisor belonging to an organization that prides itself on compassionate relations with the surrounding community). As another example, Wang et al. (2013) found that leader gender (a leader-level attribute) amplifies the negative link between authoritarian behaviors and subordinate performance, such that the relationship is stronger for women than men. They also found that the positive association between benevolent behaviors and subordinate performance is stronger for men. Wang et al.'s (2013) findings exemplify how examining the contingent relationship between leaders and leading is central to understanding the role of diversity in the leadership process. This is because diversity usually involves relatively immutable person-level attributes (aspects of individual leaders). The second row of **Figure 2** provides a visual depiction of the various ways that leading can be contingent on the relatively immutable features of leaders and also how outcomes associated with leaders can be contingent on specific behaviors associated with leading.

5.3. Approaches that Combine Causal and Contingent Relationships

An even more nuanced—and especially thought-provoking—possibility involves integrating causal and contingent approaches (see **Figure 2**, third row). For example, the relationship between a leader attribute and leading can be moderated by a separate leader attribute. Along these lines, Tost et al. (2013) found that a leader's power increases their propensity to act in a

dominant manner, and, in turn, harms team communication and performance. However, this pattern only sustains when the person holds a formally recognized position as a leader, which influences whether and when other team members believe the leader's authority is legitimate. Another possibility is that a separate leader attribute moderates the relationship between leading and a leader attribute. To illustrate, Wang et al. (2018) found that a leader action (expressing anger) influenced whether employees evaluated the leader positively; however, whether the leader was categorized as abusive moderated this effect.

6. ANALYSIS: MOVING FORWARD BY TAKING A CRITICAL LOOK BACKWARD

Substantial amounts of time, attention, and funding are dedicated every year to the study of leadership. As such, the stakes are not trivial for getting the science right. The two-part framework presented in this article—distinguishing between (a) the study of leaders and leading and (b) leadership as an independent versus dependent variable—may be helpful for not only synthesizing and reviewing existing research but also critically analyzing the state of the science in an effort to guide future research. I now pivot to this critical analysis. It leads to three basic conclusions. First, the most promising area of future research involves explicitly disentangling the role of leaders and leading within the same study. Second, critical areas of inquiry have gone almost entirely unexamined. Third, an extensive amount of research on leading has been dedicated to theories that may be misspecified. I suggest that these theories should be respecified, repurposed, or possibly even abandoned. I now expand on these three major issues while paying special attention to “bright spots”—existing studies of leadership that are exemplary and worth emulating (see **Table 1** for a summary of the key recommendations from my critical analysis of the literature).

6.1. Doing More of What Works: Decoupling and Synthesizing Leaders and Leading

The main organizing principle of this article is the distinction between leaders and leading. Although it is true that leaders and leading should be theoretically and empirically separated, I do not suggest that they should be studied *separately*. After all, it is leaders who do the leading. Thus, it is inevitable that researchers will strive to theorize and test both leaders and leading simultaneously. When this happens, it is easy to confuse and confound the two approaches from a theoretical and statistical point of view. As such, the question is not whether the study of leaders and leading should be integrated, but how this integration can be achieved.

Rather than studying leaders and leading in separate articles, I argue that the science of leadership will advance more systematically if scholars account for leaders and leading at the same time, but with separate variables. I covered examples of this approach in Section 5, Integrating the Study of Leaders and Leading. This includes research on how a person who exhibits certain behaviors is more likely to be viewed as a legitimate leader [i.e., a behavior, such as a focus on change, causes someone to be classified as a leader (Gerpott et al. 2019)], leaders who are viewed as more prototypical have the confidence to lead more effectively (Jackson & Johnson 2012), and certain forms of leading have effects only if they are enacted by people categorized as formal rather than informal leaders (Tost et al. 2013).

Figure 2 maps the ways that the study of leaders and leading can be integrated. Of special note are integrative approaches that have been largely overlooked. For instance, scholars over the past decade have largely neglected occasions when the effect of a leader attribute is moderated by leading (e.g., perhaps the effect of leader conscientiousness on group productivity is moderated by

Table 1 Recommendations for future research

Focus area	Dominant patterns in existing research	Recommendations for future research
Position of leadership within causal models	Positioning leading as an independent variable	More frequently positioning leading as a dependent variable
Leading as an independent variable	Lumping multiple behaviors within a single construct	Focusing on features of single behaviors that occur in discrete episodes
Leading as a dependent variable	Examining attributes of training programs (e.g., program length)	Examining how effectively leaders acquire specific behaviors
Interplay between leaders and leading	Examining concepts associated with leaders (e.g., leader traits, how leaders are evaluated) separately from leading (e.g., the process in which people attempt to motivate others toward a common goal)	Focusing on the interplay between leaders and leading by modeling them as separate factors within the same theory
Behavioral core of leading (direction, initiation, and persistence)	Understanding how leaders provide direction	Understanding how leaders boost action initiation and persistence
The leader as an independent variable	Identifying linear effects and main effects	Identifying curvilinear effects and boundary conditions, especially reversals
Desirability of leadership	Assuming that attaining leadership positions is desirable	Identifying costs of attaining and maintaining a leadership position, and taking self-selection more seriously (many people do not want to become the CEO)
Leader emergence and leader effectiveness	Focusing on separate causes of leader emergence and leader effectiveness	Determining whether the factors that predict leader emergence might detract from leader effectiveness, and vice versa
When an attribute of leading morphs into an attribute of a leader	Taking for granted the distinctions between ephemeral behaviors that are not tied to a person's stable personality (e.g., one-off actions, behavioral episodes) and stable behavioral patterns (e.g., habits, behavioral orientations, traits)	Carefully delineating the relationship between short-term and long-term patterns of behavior as well as situational features that make people act in stable ways, even if they do not have an underlying disposition to do so

the leader's clarity of communication) or when a predictor of leading is moderated by an attribute of the leader (e.g., perhaps the impact of a leader development program on vision communication depends on leader narcissism). To gain a well-rounded understanding of the points of overlap between leaders and leading, scholars should account for these possibilities.

Of course, scholars will often want to emphasize either leaders or leading in their theorizing and methods, depending on the research question. But even when scholars do not explicitly model both leaders and leading, I suggest that leadership research will advance more systematically if they acknowledge that the effects of one likely depend on the other in their introduction and discussion sections. A norm of acknowledging the interplay between leaders and leading can guide future research while also preventing confusion about which level of analysis is being examined.

In short, distinguishing variables at the level of leaders (e.g., demographic characteristics) from variables at the level of leading (e.g., motivating followers to exert more effort) and then examining their interplay will enable proper theoretical and empirical specification and, in turn, a more precise and complete picture of leadership in any given setting. Furthermore, by bringing them into the fold in the same studies while keeping them specified as separate constructs, the distinctions between leaders and leading may ultimately become clearer, potentially helping to prevent future instances of misspecification.

When researchers are interested in examining multiple behaviors in the same study, it is advisable in most situations to separate them into different constructs in both the theory and methods. This can be done via variance partitioning models, in which researchers allow for the likelihood that each behavior has a unique set of antecedents and consequences, and that the best way to understand how multiple behaviors influence the same outcome is by analyzing each one separately while controlling for the others. This can also be achieved via process models, in which scholars examine how leaders enact behaviors one after the other, such that each behavior can be enacted more effectively if it was preceded by a specific behavior. For example, the effectiveness of subgoals might depend on leaders first constricting attention to a single common goal (Carton 2018).

6.2. Improving How Scholars Prioritize Among Topics

With respect to the study of leaders, research on categorization, emergence, and evaluation continues to be healthy. However, there are important opportunities for growth. One involves boundary conditions and second-order effects of leader traits, including work on curvilinear effects of Big Five factors, negative effects of ostensibly “good” qualities (e.g., extroversion and conscientiousness), and conditions that complicate the negative effects of dark qualities such as narcissism. Additionally, research on the downsides of attaining leadership positions for the leaders themselves is an especially intriguing new area worthy of greater attention (Gabriel et al. 2020). Another area that has been overlooked has been the role of culture. Little is currently known about how the cultural background of leaders attenuates or amplifies certain effects between leading and key outcomes. Additionally, little is known about how culture influences how leaders are appraised and which leaders are selected (compare with Gündemir et al. 2019).

In regards to the study of leading, scholars can employ a dimensional scaling approach to establish the extent to which different behaviors are more or less indicative of the three core, definitional criteria of leading: directing, initiating, and maintaining action toward a common purpose (see **Figure 1**). In the spirit of Hollenbeck et al.’s (2012) dimensional scaling approach, scholars can open their construct definition sections by locating the behavior(s) under investigation on all three dimensions as if they were coordinates on a Leadership GPS Map. Such an approach can enable a more systematic and linear accumulation of research. It can also help identify topics that are deeply relevant to some or all of the three aspects of leadership but have not received commensurate attention. Whereas some concepts, including vision communication, are being examined with increasing frequency, other concepts are relatively neglected. Of particular note are behaviors that involve helping people initiate action. Motivating employees to take action with tactics such as goal setting and removing obstacles was a key consideration in past decades, including in work that focused on initiating structure (Judge et al. 2004), leadership and goal setting (Locke 1999), and path-goal theory (House 1996). In recent years, however, these topics have fallen out of favor.

A dimensional scaling approach can also help identify false negatives—topics that technically fall within the domain of leading but were not labeled as such by the study authors. This may involve forms of goal setting and meaning-making that involve managers helping people understand, and better regulate effort in service of, the purpose that unifies their efforts (Kim 2018). Additionally, it can help scholars identify false positives—concepts that are labeled leadership even though they only meet the criteria of leading to a negligible degree. For instance, laissez-faire leadership involves apathy and neglect and thus should probably not bear the label of leadership, even if it is performed by a person who has the formal title of a leader (Breevaart & Zacher 2019).

Finally, whereas a wealth of research has been invested in leader-level attributes as independent and dependent variables and leading as an independent variable, much less attention has been

dedicated to the study of leading as a dependent variable (compare with Lacerenza et al. 2017). Yet this area may be the most practically relevant of all areas of leadership research, because it pertains to how people can acquire behaviors that are central to leadership and known to predict valued outcomes. Toward this end, it is disconcerting that research with potentially the greatest practical import has received such little attention. As scholars focus more attention on leader interventions, I suggest that they focus their attention on the acquisition of specific behaviors, such as providing constructive feedback, rather than the attributes of the training program, such as whether feedback is given to leaders from multiple sources versus single sources or on-site versus off-site (compare with Lacerenza et al. 2017). When scholars and practitioners conceive of leadership training as the acquisition of specific behaviors (e.g., vision communication), it is likely to spur them to articulate the conditions (e.g., organizational culture) and interventions (e.g., mental time travel) that explicitly spur those behaviors.

6.3. (Mis)understanding the Multilevel Nature of Leadership

Following from the distinction between leaders (individuals who occupy positions) and leading (behaviors that influence employees), leadership is inherently a multilevel construct that can most precisely and comprehensively be investigated at two levels of analysis. According to the precepts of multilevel theory, behaviors are nested within leaders, not vice versa (Kozlowski & Klein 2000). That is, individual leaders enact many different behaviors (some but not all of which are associated with leading) across the span of each work day and work week. As they do so, they carry with them certain stable, if not immutable, characteristics—such as their personality traits and demographic characteristics. Said another way, behaviors might best be understood at the within-person level, whereas leader-level effects may best be understood at the between-person level. Such a conception of leadership is consistent with both multilevel theory as well as empirical manifestations of multilevel theory, such as repeated measures, clustering, fixed effects, and hierarchical linear modeling. For instance, leader-level effects can be examined as fixed effects, whereas each leader's behaviors (and their unique consequences) can be modeled to vary week to week, day to day, or even moment to moment (Kozlowski & Klein 2000, Dinh & Lord 2012).

Scholars have previously recognized similar dichotomies, such as the distinction between leader traits and leader behaviors (DeRue et al. 2011), how leaders are trained versus how leaders behave *in medias res* (Day 2000), or how leaders are perceived versus how they exact influence (Pfeffer 1977). However, the reality that these dichotomies reflect two different levels of analysis has largely been overlooked (compare with Yammarino et al. 2005, McClean et al. 2019). This point is critical because it determines a key form of theoretical and empirical specification: whether a theory's assumptions, arguments, hypotheses, hypothesis tests, and conclusions consistently focus on the same level of analysis (leaders or leading) or focus on both levels of analysis in a consistent way.

The most important implication of this distinction is the following: Theories of leaders should be consistently specified at the leader level, and theories of leading should be consistently specified at the level of behaviors. In a figural representation, this means that leader-level attributes would reside in a separate box that represents a higher level of analysis than any single, observable behavior and the causal pathway in which it is embedded (see **Figure 1**). As such, a precise investigation of leadership—such as identifying causes and effects or detailing process models—typically requires that scholars separate leaders from leading when developing theory and measures, even when (as recommended above) they investigate both levels of analysis within a single theory, hypothesis, and/or study. This has especially important implications for one class of theories covered in this review: those that lump together many discrete leader behaviors within single constructs. I turn to this topic now.

6.3.1. The status quo: What would happen if lumped theories of leading were left unchanged?

In the effort to achieve parsimonious theories, scholars often aggregate many discrete leader behaviors within single constructs. This can be well-justified, especially when scholars are interested in prediction rather than explanation. Indeed, in some cases it may be more useful, both theoretically and practically, to lump these behaviors under a single meta-construct than to split them. For example, in leadership development it can be extremely powerful to identify a bundle of conceptually similar behaviors that empirically covary and strongly predict either negative or positive outcomes—especially if leaders who acquire one behavior within that broader bundle automatically acquire most or all of the other behaviors in that bundle.

There are other advantages to lumped theories of leading beyond leader development. Lumped theories can be useful for leader selection because the covariation that they capture often reflects dispositions, orientations, styles, and traits that some people have and others do not. If some of these orientations are more predictive than are others, or more compatible with certain organizational cultures than are others, then they can benefit leader selection theories and programs. Similar to personality traits—which involve the study of dispositions that cut across time and contexts—scholars may be interested in determining whether an individual who consistently exhibits many related behaviors (e.g., those related to humility) will be poised to consistently improve effectiveness in a single unit across time (temporal stability) or in many different units (cross-situational stability).

Additionally, lumped constructs can help organize the literature by simplifying it and enable likeminded scholars to more easily identify collaborators and audiences who share a conceptual interest that is much broader than any single leader behavior. It is likely to be easier to identify an audience interested in humble leadership than one interested in leaders who admit mistakes. Indeed, one of the hallmarks of academic expertise is the ability to identify themes that unite underlying indicators rather than to push for more granular parsing and proliferation (Heath & Heath 2007).

The advantages of lumped theories are largely rooted in the reality that they are highly predictive and have “broad bandwidth” insofar as they incorporate a good deal of information about leading within a single construct. However, there is a well-known trade-off between bandwidth and fidelity, and a corresponding trade-off between predictive power and explanatory power. Because lumped theories are thematic abstractions that are removed from the dozens of individual behavioral episodes that characterize them, they may be highly predictive but will often obscure attempts by researchers to explain why, how, and when leading impacts key outcomes (Judge et al. 2002). This is especially problematic given that most modern leadership theories prioritize not prediction but explanation: identifying antecedents, mediators, and moderators that illuminate why, how, and when leader behaviors yield specific consequences. This is likely because leading is a process that inherently involves the interplay between one person’s behavior and another person’s psychological states and reactions. That is, the notion of antecedents and explanatory mechanisms is baked into the concept itself. Furthermore, leadership is an applied concept insofar as theorists and practitioners are interested in how it can be improved, and to understand how something can be improved, it is critical to first understand how it works. The upshot is that scholars are especially interested in the conditions that shape how leadership processes unfold as well as why and when functional processes can be magnified and dysfunctional processes stymied. In other words, explanation reigns supreme.

This leads to the Achilles heel of lumped theories: It becomes increasingly difficult to explain the causes and consequences of leader behaviors (*a*) as the number of leader behaviors within a lumped construct increases and (*b*) as the antecedents, mediators, and moderators of the different

leader behaviors within a lumped construct become increasingly varied in quantity and in kind. This is in large part because the antecedents, moderators, and mediators are likely to influence, and be influenced by, each constituent element of the lumped construct in different ways. Imagine a hypothetical theory that includes two behaviors: how effectively a leader provides feedback and how fairly a leader makes resource allocation decisions. These two behaviors may empirically covary, but suppose researchers want to examine what predicts these behaviors. It is highly likely that the predictors of one behavior are distinct from the other, and these differences may be overlooked, obscured, or warped in order to conjoin them at the same level of analysis as a two-factor lumped construct of leading.

Now suppose researchers also want to specify a serial mediation chain that explains the impact of these two behaviors on employee commitment. The chances are now even higher that feedback and fairness will have distinct causal pathways. Not only are they likely to have distinct antecedents, but they are also likely to impact commitment through distinct mediation chains. Similar to the lumped leadership construct, these mediation chains can be understood via lumped or emergent constructs, but it would be difficult or impossible for these constructs to reflect the influence process as it happens in a work context, insofar as specific leader actions alter specific psychological states of employees, and, in turn, how they behave. Perhaps leader feedback impacts commitment primarily by increasing follower self-efficacy, whereas leader fairness impacts commitment primarily through a follower's belief in a just world. Even if leader fairness and feedback covary, it would not adequately reflect the influence process associated with this two-factor form of leading to omit one of these two mediators or to lump both of them together into a meta-construct that is so general that it ceases to be meaningful. Either approach would obscure how this form of leading exerts its impact in the work context.

Now suppose the researchers want to specify moderators—that is, which conditions attenuate the causes or effects of feedback and fairness. It is likely that feedback and fairness have distinct moderators, even in the very unlikely case that the above-mentioned antecedents and mediators are the same. Furthermore, the moderators may be different for feedback versus fairness on different mediated pathways (Dinh & Lord 2012).

If a researcher investigates the impact of this lumped meta-construct on employee commitment, then it becomes difficult or impossible to answer many important questions. Is one behavior more important for explaining commitment? Does each behavior influence commitment via unique mediators? Is the effect of one of these behaviors, but not the other, contingent on a factor such as resource allocation? Is one behavior easier to influence via training than the other? Are there interdependencies between both behaviors, such as interactions (e.g., perhaps specific versus vague feedback only impacts commitment when the leaders who provide this feedback also make ethical decisions)?

Now suppose scholars examine not two correlated leader behaviors but five, ten, or fifteen. The possibility of misspecification in the process of explanation rises from probable to almost certain, until it becomes almost impossible to isolate the nomological network of discrete leader behaviors from one another, both theoretically and empirically. Even scholars who comprehensively account for a host of antecedents, moderators, and mediators of varied leader behaviors will have a difficult time identifying (and explaining coherently) which of them go with which leader behaviors. This is a problem from a conceptual level, as a given theory can become unwieldy and haphazard quickly. But then it becomes an even bigger problem empirically, because lumped theories are almost always tested as unitary factors that are holistically predicted by a set of antecedents, holistically predict mediators and consequences, and are holistically conditioned by moderators.

Taken together, the chance of misspecification, imprecision, error, and confusion rise considerably, perhaps exponentially, as scholars expand their focus on a broader nomological network

in an effort to explain why, how, and when various leader behaviors impact specific outcomes. Given that leading, by definition, is a subtype of social influence, it requires the examination of why, how, and when one person influences other people via discrete behaviors and the psychological states that each of those behaviors uniquely shapes. Aggregating behaviors at a higher level of analysis ceases to reflect social influence in this way. This is a particularly acute problem for the study of social influence in organizational psychology and organizational behavior. Understanding a social influence process in organizational psychology typically requires (at a minimum) a leader behavior and a follower psychological state—and in organizational behavior it typically requires (at a minimum) a leader behavior and a follower behavior—and the *de rigueur* approach these days is to identify a leader or follower psychological state that mediates this effect. Furthermore, many theories currently include at least one moderator. As such, theories of leading can only meaningfully explain a social influence process when several mechanisms of explanation are included, increasing the likelihood that lumped theories of leading will be misspecified.

In sum, the distinction between explanation and prediction puts a damper on efforts to increase the parsimony of theories of leading by lumping together “like with like.” The bandwidth gained by including more leader behaviors within a single meta-construct is likely offset by the inability to accurately and precisely understand why, how, and when different forms of leading impact consequences such as employee commitment, burnout, engagement, well-being, and performance.

A related issue is that covarying is distinct from co-occurring. At any given point during the work day, leaders exhibit a limited set of their behavioral repertoire, and each individual behavior likely triggers a unique set of consequences via a unique causal pathway. That is, theoretical and analytical approaches to studying leading must account for how leading is a process that occurs in situ. This is especially imperative given that day-to-day behavior may vary more within leaders than between leaders (McClean et al. 2019).

In this vein, constructs that lump many behaviors into a single construct are more challenging to study because the odds of identifying each of these aspects of the nomological network are lower. As indicated in my review above, these constructs incorporate several to several dozen behaviors—and often the measures also lump in non-behaviors, including assessments of leader traits (e.g., blanket assessments of charisma, ethicality, and humility) and evaluators’ beliefs and attitudes about the leader (e.g., trust in the leader). As a result, it is almost impossible to tease apart the within-person, within-dyad, and within-situation causes and effects of many of these constructs. Often scholars can only speculate about these aspects of the influence process.

There are still other limitations that further exacerbate concerns with lumping. One of them is that whereas lumping is popular among psychologists who study traits and dispositions, scholars who examine other influence processes tend to focus on discrete behaviors that unfold within a single episode of time, such as what is prevalent in research on voice or behavioral decision theory. To attract scholars whose backgrounds and identities reside outside of leadership, it is important to recognize that they may be more familiar with the custom of differentiating among thematically similar constructs (e.g., studying only one form of justice at a time, such as procedural justice) than aggregating them.

A final concern with lumped theories of leading is that the methods used—often questionnaires that rely on individuals to rate leaders on multiple dimensions—are deeply susceptible to halo effects such that it is not clear whether these behaviors actually do covary, wherein leaders who practice one behavior actually engage in a behavior found to covary with it, or whether evaluators merely perceive an illusory covariation.

6.3.2. The way forward: Should lumped theories of leading be respecified, repurposed, or abandoned? Given the challenges associated with lumped constructs of leading, I summarize three possible alternative paths forward: respecification, repurposing, and abandonment.

6.3.2.1. The case for respecifying lumped conceptualizations of leading. Respecification would involve shifting lumped theories from conceptualizations of leading to conceptualizations of leaders. This would fundamentally change the assumptions and arguments used to build and analyze each theory. One option is to respecify them as implicit theories. In survey research, peoples' implicit theories of leadership explain as much variation in their perceptions of leader behavior as leader behavior itself (Wang et al. 2019). For example, when a leader looks a certain way (e.g., possesses dominant facial features), belongs to a high performing unit, or enacts just one behavior associated with good leadership (e.g., respectful treatment), various perceptual biases can come into play, including halo effects and associative memory (the tendency for the perception of one behavior to activate perceptions of other behaviors in a semantic network of receptors in memory). As a result, perceivers will be inclined to "see" in that leader other behaviors associated with good leadership that might not objectively be there. Ultimately, constructs such as authentic leadership and servant leadership might indicate peoples' implicit theories about their leaders better than their leaders' actual behavior. Given that surveys are such a prevalent method for assessing these forms of leadership, it may be the case that existing research is already tapping into followers' implicit leadership theories more than actual leader behaviors, suggesting that it may be possible for scholars to pivot how they conceptualize these theories more so than change the methods they use.

A second option is to respecify them as trait-based theories. This may be especially useful for theories of leadership that directly correspond to personality traits that reflect a person's overriding behavioral dispositions. For example, servant leadership may reflect a trait similar to the duty subdimension of conscientiousness (Colbert & Witt 2009), and humble leadership may be integrated more directly with work on the trait of humility (Johnson et al. 2011). This could be a boon for research on leader selection systems. Research from the Ohio State Leadership Studies in the middle of the twentieth century is an example of how a leadership model can evolve from strictly a behavioral theory of leading to a description of leader styles. This research program initially began as a battery of scales intended to distinguish between dozens of possible leader behaviors, but factor analyses unearthed two stable, basic dimensions (consideration and initiating structure) that explained a substantial degree of variance in key leadership outcomes (Judge et al. 2004). By the end of the twentieth century, these two dimensions came to be viewed as behavioral tendencies (markers of individual leaders) rather than behavioral episodes (markers of leading).

To determine whether to respecify theories as implicit theories or traits, scholars can conduct further methodological studies to parse the extent to which survey responses represent dispositional tendencies (humble leaders act in consistent ways on multiple dimensions) versus perceptual biases (people see covariation among similar behaviors even if this covariation does not exist in reality) via a variety of nonsurvey methods, including observational and archival studies.

6.3.2.2. The case for repurposing lumped conceptualizations of leading. Repurposing is an alternative to respecification, as it does not involve changing the assumptions or tenets of a theory but rather how a theory is employed. One possibility involves more frequently employing lumped theories as dependent variables in main effects models. This would involve a substantial pivot, given that the vast majority of research on lumped theories of leading features them as predictors of downstream outcomes. But it would yield numerous advantages. It would reduce the need for

lumped theories to focus on explaining a complex, multistaged, iterative social influence process. Rather, the focus can be more exclusively placed on leader behavior. This can be especially useful for research on leadership development and training. For example, in leadership development it may be extremely powerful to identify a bundle of conceptually similar behaviors that empirically covary—especially if leaders who acquire one behavior within that broader bundle automatically acquire most or all of the other behaviors in that bundle.

As a hypothetical example, consider humble leadership. Imagine that the process of learning and practicing one key behavior associated with humble leadership—admitting mistakes—spurs a process of generalized habit formation and associative learning that automatically triggers the other behaviors associated with this form of leading, such as spotlighting follower strengths, modeling teachability, granting voice, legitimizing follower development, and reversing roles with followers. In this example, a leader needs to acquire only one orienting behavior to establish a more general disposition of humility that spreads to dozens of inter-related behaviors that the leader did not consciously acquire but still reliably exhibits. This example assumes that the covariation among the distinct behaviors associated with humble leadership is both formative and reflective (MacCallum & Browne 1993). For the formative path, a single indicator (in this case, admitting mistakes) partly or wholly causes a broader latent variable (in this case, humble leadership). For the reflective path, the increase in humble leadership boosts the remaining indicators associated with that form of leadership (e.g., spotlighting follower strengths, giving voice, and modeling teachability). This approach essentially involves exploiting the covariation between behaviors lumped within meta-constructs.

Along these lines, lumped theories can help leaders better comprehend and remember leader behaviors when participating in leadership development programs. In this way, a feature of these theories that is often problematic (that they activate and influence perceivers' implicit theories of leadership) can be used for good. Research on cognitive psychology suggests that people are better able to remember ideas when they are chunked within a higher-order label (Gobet 2005). As such, even if servant leadership—as a theory of leading—cannot tease apart how, when, and why each of the 36 items impacts downstream outcomes, the reality that the range of behaviors and perceptions these items capture are packaged underneath a single umbrella term highlighting their commonalities can make training and development more efficient and effective. This is theoretically meaningful because it identifies where leader behaviors come from and practically useful because it enables practitioners to focus on a common underlying theme that unifies highly predictive behaviors rather than a multitude of disaggregated behaviors.

A final option involves treating lumped theories of leading as parent literatures that can engage and orient readers, given that readers are familiar with ideas such as transformational leadership, but then focus both hypothesis development as well as each study's empirical investigation on a specific behavior or set of disentangled behaviors that fall within the parent literature. For example, Ashford et al. (2018) opened their paper by discussing humble leadership; however, they then immediately focused their analysis on two individual behaviors, feedback seeking and vision articulation, which is more precise from the standpoint of theoretical specification. They then manipulated both behaviors with two different treatment conditions in a factorial design, which is more precise from the standpoint of empirical specification.

6.3.2.3. *The case for abandoning lumped conceptualizations of leading.* Despite considerable upside, both respecification and repurposing are laden with risks. First, it would not be clear how to reconcile traits such as servant leadership with other traits (especially the Big Five). Second, scholars would have to tease apart the distinctions between traits versus styles, orientations, and foci—labels that have all been used to capture similar ideas. Third, existing methodologies often

cannot tease apart the extent to which a construct such as servant leadership is an implicit theory such that respondents to surveys (a) subconsciously categorize leaders as more or less servant-like and then rate them according to a series of behaviors that merely reflect an implicit theory, or (b) record the leader's behaviors in a fashion that reflects the leader's actual behavior. In the former case, covariation among behaviors is a halo effect. In the latter case, the behaviors actually do covary in real life. Fourth, some of the lumped conceptualizations of leading mix behaviors (e.g., the leader asking for input) with traits, orientations, tendencies, characteristics, and styles (e.g., "the leader is caring" or "the leader helps develop my career"). This would make it difficult to respecify a lumped theory's entire set of subdimensions and items as behaviors.

It would also be challenging to repurpose theories of leading from an independent to a dependent variable. If scholars take this approach, they would still run into problems with specification, because it might be difficult to learn if, when, and why leaders learn one behavior of, say, servant leadership better than another. Additionally, scholars would not be able to study leading simultaneously as an independent and dependent variable, because of the aforementioned problems associated with specification as an independent variable. Furthermore, if the subdimensions of a construct such as servant leadership, empowering leadership, or humble leadership do covary in real life (i.e., their covariation is not a statistical artifact), the fused nature of all of the individual behaviors makes it challenging to determine whether the behaviors all have a common cause that is omitted or if one behavior is more fundamental insofar as it activates the others.

Finally, there are pragmatic considerations that reflect how scholars do their work and how knowledge tends to accumulate. Respecifying/repurposing lumped constructs can create confusion for scholars who want to synthesize research before and after the shift. It also may create issues when some researchers shift specification but others do not or when journal referees use their prior understanding of the theory's specification to evaluate a theory's updated specification.

In short, the prospect of respecifying/repurposing lumped theories is laden with coordination costs that further imperil the accumulation of knowledge. When these concerns are considered in tandem with other known limitations of lumped theories, including the tendency for surveys associated with these theories to make use of double-barreled items and for some subdimensions to be tautological (van Knippenberg & Sitkin 2013), it leaves me torn about whether to recommend a pivot toward respecification/repurposing of lumped constructs or a "clean break" such that these constructs are abandoned. The former step might preserve the value and evocativeness of longstanding leadership theories, maintain continuity in the labels used to understand leadership, and respect the decades of research and smart minds that have been dedicated to their study. At a minimum, these theories not only have established predictive validity but also have served as shared forms of meaning that galvanize communities of leadership scholars.

But my own view is that the latter approach—a wholesale break from the past—might be most generative. It would require leadership scholars to return to first principles without being constrained by the vestiges of constructs that are, in many ways, beyond repair. Fresh starts allow for clear thinking and stem escalation of commitment (Alvesson & Einola 2019, Gottfredson et al. 2020, van Knippenberg & Sitkin 2013). I encourage other scholars to articulate points of agreement and disagreement with my position here and, ultimately, to wager whether lumped conceptualizations of leading should be respecified, repurposed, abandoned, or (if I am misguided in my criticisms) left as is.

6.3.3. Avoiding future instances of misspecification. The abundance of lumped theories raises the question of why they are so popular, despite their inherent limitations. In an effort to guide future research, I speculate about some reasons here.

The first involves etymology—theories that emerged for one purpose and then drifted to another without clear justification. Many of the most influential lumped conceptualizations of

leadership, including transformational leadership and charismatic leadership, had their origins in social science disciplines other than organizational behavior. For example, the idea of a transforming leader arose in history to explain the arc of specific leaders, such as Gandhi, across time and place (Burns 1978). Accordingly, these perspectives were not intended to facilitate the study of the causes and effects of individual behaviors *in situ*.

The second is intuition. The study of leaders is intuitive, whereas the study of leading is not. It is easier to think about the phenomenon of leadership at the level of the leader than the level of behaviors (Schlenker & Weigold 1989). People tend to classify and simplify the world at the level of the individual, such that it is easier to make assessments about individual traits or general states of being than to make assessments about individual behaviors that are not explicitly tied to identifiable individuals (Macrae & Bodenhausen 2000). People are easily distinguishable from one another, whereas behaviors are fuzzy and sometimes spill into each other. A person is perceived as a complete whole; a behavior, less so. In this way, it may appear to make more sense to think that the “atom”—the most fundamental unit of analysis—in any given situation involving leadership is the leader rather than a behavior associated with leading. Moreover, people do not merely find a focus on the individual leader as more intuitive but also preferable. Hunt (1999) noted that transformational and charismatic leadership rejuvenated the study of leadership in part because of their focus on extraordinary individuals (e.g., Nelson Mandela and Margaret Thatcher) rather than stand-alone behaviors. But what is intuitive and easily understandable does not necessarily most closely reflect the phenomenon of interest.

The third reason is convention. There are several common practices that reinforce the tendency to lump multiple behaviors into single constructs. One popular approach is to create a construct and label it “leadership” with a modifier before the word leadership (e.g., authentic leadership, charismatic leadership, empowering leadership, ethical leadership, humble leadership, servant leadership, or transformational leadership). This convention implies that a set of leader behaviors can best be understood as a single theoretical construct that can be modeled in an undifferentiated manner. Instead, it may be more helpful to consider a label such as “empowering leadership” not as a construct that can be hypothesized or modeled as a single variable, but as an area of research or a subdiscipline that captures a range of related behaviors that need to be teased apart in separate programs of research.

There are also methodological conventions that encourage misspecification (van Knippenberg & Sitkin 2013). Perceivers are unlikely to detect an accurate amount of variation across discrete behaviors practiced by a given leader when asked about these discrete behaviors all at once, even via validated scales. These devices are susceptible to halo effects, such that leaders who are superlative in one sense are viewed as superlative in others. And even when scholars correlate survey measures with objective measures of performance in order to reduce common method variance (Podsakoff et al. 2003), the surveys may still be biased by the tendency for perceivers to attribute good things to leaders who lead in the context of success. Thus, although it is typically appropriate for social cognitive theories of leaders to use methods that reflect perception, cognition, and categorization (e.g., surveys with self-report questionnaire items or Q sorting), these methods may be less appropriate for theories of leading because of the tendency for halo effects. These shortcomings highlight a danger of statistical machinery. When scales with excellent psychometric properties reinforce a theory’s flaws (specification at the level of the leader rather than the level of the behavior), they may create illusory empirical support for those flaws. The methodology almost perfectly obscures misspecification, leading to a cycle whereby theories that do not provide explanatory power at the level that the phenomenon takes place (as an influence process between two or more individuals) appear strongly supported, and, in turn, beget more scholarly attention (van Knippenberg & Sitkin 2013).

By contrast, unobtrusive methods such as content analysis (e.g., video, audio, or text coding) can be particularly effective for assessing leading as long as the observable manifestations of the behaviors are well-defined. Content analysis allows raters to account for discrete leader behaviors before performance outcomes are measured. Additionally, controlled experiments certainly can (and should) be used to capture the consequences of single behavioral episodes in an internally valid way; however, it is better to examine multiple leadership behaviors in a factorial design than to force-fit them into a single treatment condition.

The final consideration is practicality. Whereas scholars can examine entire traits of leaders in one study, it is impossible to capture the construct of leading in one study; rather, it requires a program of research. Consistent with the issue of bandwidth fidelity and the trade-off between comprehensiveness and precision (Ones & Viswesvaran 1996), although it may appear that more variance in outcomes can be explained by specifying behavior at the level of the leader, it is much more difficult to precisely specify causes and effects at this level of analysis.

Given that the limitations of lumped theories are so firmly rooted in biases that all researchers (that is, all humans) have, including the desire to follow convention, intuition, and practicality, it is essential that the community of leadership scholars generate norms to guard against gratuitous lumping. I suggest that the best ways to do this are for more researchers to ask whether the antecedents, mediators, and moderators that are most frequently studied in tandem with lumped theories can explain all of the behaviors that are subsumed within a lumped theory in the same way. Even though a lumped theory may appear to have substantial reach, that reach may come at the cost of so much precision that it renders the science untenable. As a result, it may be best for scholars to respecify, repurpose, or abandon lumped theories and direct more of their attention to isolating single leader behaviors.

7. CONCLUSION

The distinctions between (*a*) leaders and leading and (*b*) leadership as a cause versus a consequence can provide scholars with a framework for organizing existing research, identifying areas in need of greater scrutiny, and directing attention toward the most promising theories and paradigms. Overall, the study of leaders stands in great health. By contrast, the study of leading is haphazard, especially when it is featured as an independent variable. To continue to advance the science of leading, scholars should pay particular attention to the attributes that make lumped theories seductive despite their serious limitations and ask whether the upside to these theories is worth the considerable cost. Although focusing on the causes and consequences of individual leader behaviors may result in leadership research plodding along in a highly piecemeal and fragmented fashion, such an approach may be the best way to do justice to the complexity of the phenomenon and slowly but surely accumulate evidence in the most rigorous fashion possible.

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